

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

2012-08-09

283

50

9 August 2012

The National Spiritual Assembly of
the Bahá'ís of the United States

Dear Bahá'í Friends,

50.1 The establishment of ten Regional Bahá'í Councils in your country is an auspicious moment, occurring at a time when the Bahá'í community of the United States finds itself in a fortified condition, forward-looking and eager to learn from experience.

guidance provided in its messages on the Five Year Plan has been, and continues to be, the object of thoughtful study, forming the

basis upon which systematic action is being undertaken. It is

clear that the friends are acquiring greater familiarity with the dynamics of growth, especially when they see how a fresh sense

of community life can emerge, within a neighborhood or town,

as the core activities called for by the Plan become deeply rooted.

50.2 In each of your regions, encouraging signs appear. A

perceived dichotomy that had arisen between classes offered for children living close to one another and centralized schools

covering a broader area is yielding to a more mature under -

standing. Through participation in the courses of the training institute, an ever-greater number of friends are enhancing their capacity to offer spiritual education to those they encounter in

the wider society. Classes for the young initiated at the neigh-

borhood level for this purpose are multiplying. In those places where the junior youth spiritual empowerment program has

become firmly established, its importance as a vital component

of the community-building process is becoming increasingly

apparent; it is more promising still that the first two clusters to function as sites for the dissemination of learning about this program have now emerged. The spirit of collaboration among the institutions of the Faith, at every level of the administration, is more and more evident. These are the favorable circumstances—

284

FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONEs in which more than four score believers, eager to stimulate the process of growth across the United States, are assuming their responsibilities as members of the newly reconstituted Regional Bahá'í Councils. They do so knowing that their primary task is to support and guide the work of expansion and consolidation in cluster after cluster. With this in mind, the House of Justice has requested us to convey a number of comments that it is hoped will be of assistance to these devoted friends as they embark on the work before them.

50.3 The message of 28 December 2010 from the Universal House of Justice describing the features of the current Five Year Plan makes direct reference to the responsibilities exercised by Regional Councils. The House of Justice highlights, among other things, the need for Councils to pay close attention to the operation of the regional institute, including the scheme of coordination the institute establishes at the level of the cluster. The Councils must ensure, too, the timely appearance and dynamic functioning of Area Teaching Committees. The discharge of these duties, carried out with the assistance of the Counsellors and their auxiliaries, will serve to foster the participation of increasing numbers of the friends in a rising number of programs of growth—and this, in turn, conduces to the sound development of the individual, the community, and the institutions. Overall, a Council would wish to be well informed about the conditions that prevail in each cluster in the region. Further, as you will be aware from the 12 December 2011 message of the House of Justice to all National Spiritual Assemblies, there are two complementary perspectives from which the Councils will be able to view the pattern of action

in a cluster: the “three-month cycles of activity through which a community grows” and the emergence of “an educational process with three distinct stages.”

50.4 As they analyze what occurs in a cluster through successive cycles of activity, Regional Councils will benefit from drawing upon the system that has been developed in the Bahá’í world for the generation and dissemination of knowledge about growth; in this connection, the Councils’ direct relationship with the Counsellors assumes special significance. Thus will experience gained from the advancement of clusters in your own and other countries provide a store of insight as well as inspiration.

Naturally, this knowledge will be derived not only from the successes that accrue, but also from instances where progress in

285

for signs that learning continues to be the mode of operation at the level of the cluster. As one cycle follows after another, there should be a steady rise in the friends’ capacity to apply the guidance they have received, to reflect on their own experience in light of what is being learned worldwide, to improve their efforts, and to surmount the obstacles they encounter.

50.5 With respect to the educational process whose emergence in clusters is essential to the community-building work everywhere, the 12 December message describes its dynamics in some detail. Although neighborhood classes for the spiritual education of children and the junior youth spiritual empowerment program both took some time to become well established in the United States, there is every sign that they are set to flourish. As indicated above, the prospects for the junior youth program are especially bright. Its impact can be seen in the transformation that occurs within the junior youth who are its participants; they come to regard themselves as agents of social change, each endowed with a twofold sense of purpose that impels them to take charge of their own spiritual and intellectual growth and contribute to the welfare of society. It is noteworthy, however, that the program’s beneficial effects are also apparent in the

rapid moral and spiritual development of many young people, be they Bahá'ís or not, who are assisted to serve as animators.

50.6 Regional Councils, then, should become adept at analyzing the conditions in each cluster from both perspectives set out in the 12 December message. But from either perspective, the critical importance of systematically developing human resources—which lies at the heart of the Plan—must remain in view.

For unless a capacity for human resource development is well established in a cluster, there can be no expectation of sustained

progress. Conversely, a Bahá'í community that gains solid experience in this work will not only have enhanced its ability to attract growing contingents to the Cause of God; it will also find

itself able to rally a perpetually expanding body of individuals dedicated to the transformation of the society around them.

50.7 That this process should advance at varying speeds within various populations is to be expected; it is a natural feature of an organic phenomenon. It should certainly not become a cause of anxiety. The Plan's methods and instruments endow the Bahá'í community with the means to labor effectively in every setting—from the university campus to the urban
286

FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONneighborhood, from the rural town to the city suburb. Yet, as you clearly appreciate, to expect the rate at which growth occurs in one instance to be matched in every other, or to curtail the process within one population because others are not equally served, would be wholly unreasonable and ultimately counterproductive. In short, those responsible for coordinating the endeavors of the friends should be ever sensitive to the

natural unfoldment of the processes they oversee—conscious of when greater intensity is required in one area and when patience and encouragement are called for in another. Within each population, the path of learning will thus open up.

50.8 Accepting, indeed welcoming, the dynamics that characterize each set of circumstances will help the friends to refrain from drawing unhelpful comparisons between the progress

experienced in one area or by one group of believers and that reported elsewhere. The friends will be involved in the work according to their capacities and the possibilities before them. Some will, in the settings where they find themselves, reach out to family, friends, colleagues, and acquaintances, inviting them to take part in core activities. Others will become integrated into neighborhoods and dedicate themselves to assisting particularly receptive populations to advance along a path of spiritual development—giving rise to centers of intense activity. Of course, where a special measure of receptivity has been recognized, resources will need to be deployed to enable it to blossom. However, the institutions of the Faith need to guard against stifling an instance of rapid growth in a neighborhood by calling on too many individuals from outside to become involved in fledgling efforts.

50.9 The House of Justice has previously indicated, in letters written to you on its behalf, the importance of giving due attention to historically significant populations in the United States. This imperative remains. Today, the remarkable phenomenon of immigration that has accelerated in recent decades must also claim a major share of your attention. After all, immigrants—whether from the Latin regions of your own continent, across the Pacific from Asia or the Atlantic from Africa—constitute a sizable proportion of the American population. Their sons and daughters now apparently number almost one in four of the children in your country. Among these families whose origins lie beyond your borders a vibrant sense of community is often more pronounced. Raising capacity within these populations

287

plement the program for the spiritual empowerment of their junior youth, will enhance the vitality of community-building endeavors in many clusters.

50.10 Intensifying efforts to reach out to a receptive population carries certain implications for the scheme of coordination in a cluster. As indicated in the 12 December message, the International Teaching Centre is following experience around

the world to articulate what form the elements of an effective organizational scheme assume under diverse circumstances.

In this regard, the Counsellors and their auxiliaries will work closely with the Regional Councils, institute boards, and cluster

agencies; your Assembly will, undoubtedly, wish to engage in regular consultation with the Counsellors on this theme to assess the implications of new insights for expansion and consolidation in the United States.

50.11 This leads naturally to the consideration of some points that will require the close attention of your Assembly, for the acceleration of the process of growth has profound ramifications for the organization of your National Center.

You will recall that a letter to you dated 19 October 2005, written on behalf of the House of Justice, explored in some detail the administrative challenges associated with large-scale

expansion. The broad principles elucidated therein continue to apply to your present situation. The letter highlighted the importance of decentralization in order to allow for the necessary

flexibility to respond to needs at the grass roots. While many productive steps have been taken, further changes are required to enable you to provide the financial resources necessary to

sustain a rising number of programs of growth. Moreover, it seems likely that the same flexibility—and, at times, innovative

thinking—will be needed in the approach to the provision of

funds to support part- and full-time workers in the regions and clusters. It should be expected that, in the future, increasing

responsibility will devolve to these levels. A periodic review of the mandates and the functioning of programs and offices

affiliated with your National Center is necessary to ensure a

suitable balance of structures and an appropriate distribution of resources at all levels. Even your internal arrangements for

maintaining an open channel of communication between your

Assembly and the Regional Councils would benefit from review

288

FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONso that you remain fully informed of advances made in the

implementation of the Plan nationwide.

50.12 A new chapter in the evolution of the Administrative Order in the United States is now opening, endowed with immense promise. As those dedicated believers called to serve on Regional Councils now take up their responsibilities, no doubt they will be conscious that they function as members of corporate bodies and not, of course, as individual leaders. Indeed, it will be essential for them to remain mindful of the admonitions in the Bahá'í writings that apply to all those charged with the administration of the affairs of the Faith—that they are to approach their work in the spirit of “humble fellowship” and that they must not allow themselves to be considered the “central ornaments of the body of the Cause.” So promising a process of growth unfolding in your country at the level of the cluster should not come to revolve around their expectations or to rely on their personal presence. Guarding against the least trace of any such tendency will greatly redound to their effectiveness. For the reality of the situation in many instances is that the richest experience exists at the grass roots, when a nucleus of believers labors intensively to build capacity within a population to take charge of its own spiritual and social advancement. All those who aim to assist the process of learning at this level must remain sensitive to conditions in individual clusters, lest frequent requests for reports or summons to gatherings—however well intentioned—sap energy or dissipate focus. Rather will they wish to do everything within their means to provide support, to lovingly encourage, to facilitate the efforts under way, and to respond, with flexibility and dispatch, to needs as they arise.

50.13 The House of Justice deeply appreciates your earnest exertions to attend to the requirements of the Five Year Plan. It acknowledges receipt of your email letter dated 18 July 2012 enclosing the names of those believers who have the privilege to serve on the Regional Councils in the United States. You are assured that the House of Justice will offer its ardent supplications at the Sacred Threshold on their behalf. May Bahá'u'lláh

continue to bless and confirm the endeavors of the American
community in the path of service to His Cause.

With loving Bahá'í greetings,

Department of the Secretariat

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]